

1542

EUROPEANS EXPLORE NORTH AMERICA

Hernando de Soto – a Spanish soldier who had taken part in the conquest of Inca Peru – mounted an expedition to explore what is now the southern US. Advancing from Florida through lands inhabited by Indigenous peoples, he became the first European to reach the Mississippi in 1541. He died there the following year.

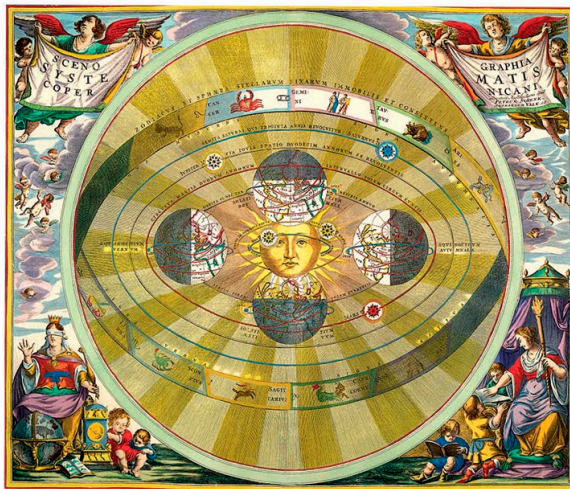


▽ Hernando de Soto

1543

COPERNICAN REVOLUTION

In his book *On the Revolutions of the Celestial Spheres* published in 1543, Polish astronomer Nicolaus Copernicus proposed that Earth and the planets revolved around the Sun – Earth was not the centre of the universe. His theory was adopted by astronomers from the late 16th century but resisted by the Catholic Church.



△ The Copernican system, 1600 illustration

1540

1541 Michelangelo completes painting the ceiling of the Vatican's Sistine Chapel

1541 Calvinism spreads as preacher Jean Calvin founds a Protestant Republic in Geneva

1545 At the Council of Trent, Catholic Church leaders plan a Counter-Reformation (to 1563)

1543

PORTUGUESE IMPACT ON JAPAN

The first European sailors to reach Japan were Portuguese traders. Their arrival in 1543 was welcomed by the Japanese because they brought goods from China.

The Ming emperors had banned direct trade with Japan, so the Portuguese found a valuable niche as intermediaries. The Portuguese also introduced firearms, which were soon being manufactured in Japan, transforming samurai warfare. Jesuit missionaries, arriving from 1549, won thousands of Japanese converts, but Christianity was later suppressed.



▷ *Arrival of a Portuguese Ship*, Japanese screen, c. 1620